

# Nordic Ministry Snapshot

## Through the Eyes of Pastor Billy Lo

the Nordic Chinese Christian Church (NCCC) – Stockholm, Sweden

*Interviewed by Pastor Enoch Liao | CCCOWE 2026 Explore360, Kuching, Malaysia*

**Pastor Billy Lo** is 1.5-generation — born in Hong Kong, brought to Sweden at age two, raised in Stockholm. He became the first Christian in his family through the Chinese heritage church he grew up in. He went to Bible seminary, was ordained in 2014, and has now been pastoring that same home church for 23 years. He serves as the senior pastor of the Stockholm congregation of the Nordic Chinese Christian Church (NCCC), a transnational network of six congregations across four sovereign nations: Sweden (Stockholm, Gothenburg, Malmö), Norway (Oslo, Stavanger), Finland (Helsinki), and an emerging mission presence in Denmark (Copenhagen). For roughly ten to fifteen years, Billy was the only next-generation pastor in the entire NCCC network — the one person who had grown up in the Nordic countries and was pastoring in the languages people actually spoke.

Billy speaks from 23 years in one place, and from the rare vantage of a pastor who belongs to the community he serves. What follows is not a survey. It is one seasoned pastor's account of what he has seen, navigated, and learned — in a context that looks quite unlike any other stop on the Explore360 map.

### ▪ Who Are the People? From One Language to Four

The Nordic Chinese heritage church began with one wave and one language.

Forty years ago, when the first three congregations started — Stockholm, Oslo, and Gothenburg — the community was almost entirely Cantonese-speaking, with roots in Hong Kong and some from Taiwan. Most had come for the restaurant trade. Many worked in Chinese restaurants and takeaways, not as professionals or students. Billy describes it plainly: "Most of them, they don't have the high education — because most of them, the third generation, they work in the restaurant business. So that is the group we had in the beginning." For the church's first decade or so, this actually simplified things. Meetings for all ages ran in one language. "In the beginning, it was easier language-wise because when we had meetings, both the adults and young people, we only spoke Cantonese."

That changed in the 1990s. Mainland Chinese immigration into the Nordic countries began to reshape who the churches were serving. Mandarin speakers arrived — younger, more educated,

with a different cultural register entirely. Today, across the NCCC, Mandarin speakers form the majority and span a range of ages. The original Cantonese-speaking community has aged: "The Cantonese background, the Hong Kong people, they are the older people and most of them is retired." Their children and grandchildren are still in some congregations — the third generation that grew up in the church — but the shared linguistic floor of the founding era is gone.

One thing that has not happened in the Nordic countries: the BNO wave. When Britain opened pathways for Hong Kongers after 2021, Chinese heritage churches in Birmingham and London saw an overnight influx of tens of thousands of new arrivals. I asked Billy whether something similar had reached Scandinavia. "No, the government doesn't open this opportunity for the Hong Kong people." The Nordic countries made different policy choices. Immigration still happens — primarily students coming from mainland China — but there has been no sudden demographic shift. "We are as usual very stable," Billy says.

Stable, but linguistically complex. The Stockholm congregation now runs two services: a combined Cantonese-Mandarin service for the older and middle generations, and an English-language service for the younger community. Swedish used to be the language of that younger service. It no longer is.

## ▪ The Language Question

---

No other Chinese heritage church context makes this question quite as concrete as the Nordic one.

What do you do when no one's native language is the language you started with — and when the common tongue that connects everyone is not even a Chinese language?

Billy walked me through the progression. The founding Cantonese-speaking congregation gave way, over time, to a second generation that was more Swedish than Cantonese. The church added Swedish services. But more recently — and this is the move I didn't expect — the Swedish services were dropped in favor of English. "We switched," Billy said. Why? "We are thinking that maybe English will be more inclusive — include other people. For example, if you have suddenly some people from China and they are very young and they choose to come, join the next-gen people, so we use English instead."

What has made this possible is that English fluency among young people in Sweden has become near-universal. "The English level for the young people in Sweden or Nordic countries is increasing a lot. The English is very good. And sometimes I think it's kind of because the English is so strong, the local language is kind of neglected in some way, because people speak English too often."

The practical result: the NCCC's common cross-border language when the network gathers is English. Not Mandarin, not Cantonese — English. When Billy operates across the NCCC network,

he moves between Mandarin, Cantonese, Swedish, and English. Some of the young people from the Helsinki congregation can do more. I mentioned one young woman I had met at a Nordic summer camp years ago who could count seven languages — Cantonese, Mandarin, English, Finnish, Swedish, and others. Billy did not find this surprising.

This is a sharper version of the question every Chinese heritage church eventually faces: what happens to cultural and linguistic identity when the second generation's Chinese isn't strong enough to sustain ministry in Chinese? In the United States, that question usually means English. In the Nordic context, it meant Swedish for a generation — and now it means English again, but for different reasons. The language has become universal, not cultural. That changes what "a Chinese heritage church" even means for the people who call it home.

In Helsinki, the NCCC has gone one step further. A new congregation has been born out of the Chinese heritage church there, led by a next-generation pastor named Chun Chun. They don't call it an English service. They call it an international church. Billy lit up when he described it: "God bless and God led them to start an international church. So they will not say 'English.' They will say 'international' — because the goal and the mission for them is to reach out to different kinds of people." That is not just a naming choice. It is a mission posture — a Chinese heritage church deliberately shedding the ethnic frame for the congregation it is planting.

## ▪ One Church, Four Nations

---

The structural fact about the NCCC that makes it unlike anything I've encountered in the American, British, Canadian, or Australian contexts: it is one church operating across four sovereign nations under four different legal and religious regimes, with congregations that span multiple languages and have each built their own local culture over four decades.

It started from necessity. "Especially in the beginning, because all the churches are so small and the resources are so limited, we need to get together to support each other." Three tiny Cantonese congregations — Stockholm, Oslo, Gothenburg — found strength in joint ministry they couldn't find alone. Summer camp, youth gatherings, conferences: shared across borders from the beginning. Over 40 years, what started as a survival mechanism became something more like a shared identity. "Now after 40 years, we still think that being together, exploring together, developing together is something that is natural for us. It's natural for us."

The network has grown from three to six. Oslo has an English service. Stavanger is in Norway. Malmö is in Sweden. Helsinki is in Finland, affiliated in an unusual ecumenical arrangement with the Finnish Evangelical Lutheran Mission — uncommon texture for a Chinese heritage church network. Copenhagen is in Denmark, still in a mission phase. When the NCCC gathers, the languages multiply and the sovereign borders dissolve.

The pastoral effect on people who grew up in this network is hard to overstate. Young people who attended the Nordic summer camps year after year got to know peers from five countries. Some of them married each other. Some moved between cities and found the church waiting for them. The Chinese heritage church in Stockholm is their church, and so is the one in Oslo, and the one in Helsinki — not conceptually but relationally. Billy was the connective tissue for years: the one next-gen pastor building relationships across the whole network while the founding generation aged.

But Billy raises the honest question: as each local church grows larger and more self-sufficient, does the joint structure still make sense? "When the churches are getting bigger, you have more things to do in your local church, you don't have that much time and energy to put on the joint ministry that we have." He asks it plainly: "Do we really need to stick together continually?" He doesn't answer it. Neither will I. It is the live, honest question of an organization at an inflection point after forty years of doing something remarkable — and doing it so well that the local churches are now strong enough to question whether the scaffold is still needed.

## ▪ Secularity, Rest, and What Comes Next

---

Sweden is among the most secular societies on earth. I asked Billy how the Chinese heritage church navigates that — whether the surrounding secularity creates pressure, or clarity, or something else.

His answer surprised me. He did not lead with difficulty. He led with something he has been watching outside the Chinese community entirely.

"The younger generation — it seems like they have more interest to go to the church. And actually they are more interested to go to the traditional church — for example, the Orthodox Church." He thinks the deeper hunger is for meaning that secular frameworks cannot provide. "Maybe it's because there's a need for a deeper understanding about life. Because maybe because of the secular age, the questions that we have are not answered by the things that only we can see or hear — maybe there is a deeper meaning."

He gave me a concrete moment. He attended a graduation party for an eighteen-year-old in his congregation. When he arrived, the party was already a small ecumenical gathering: people from the NCCC, people from a Hillsong community, people from a local Swedish church — all together in one room, thrown by a young man who wanted to celebrate graduating. At the end of the party, the young man asked if they could close with a worship set. They did. Billy described it as "really special" — twice. I think he meant it twice as much.

That image — three communities, one room, worship as the close — is the sharpest version of what he sees happening among young Swedish Christians. The secularity that flattened the broader culture may have, paradoxically, clarified the cost of belonging to something. The young

people who are still in church, and still reaching toward other churches, know what they are choosing.

What the Chinese heritage churches in the Nordic context are grappling with is not primarily secularity as an external threat. It is exhaustion as an internal reality. When Billy told me the theme for the 2026 NCCC summer camp — "Rooted in Rest" — I asked who chose it. He wasn't in the room when it was decided. But he found it telling: "When I first saw the topic, I was just thinking that it seems like people are really, really exhausted nowadays." He let the observation sit for a moment and then asked the harder question underneath it: "Is there any other thing? Because I think this problem also affects how we run the church — because if the brothers and sisters are always very tired, then talking about discipleship and serving is kind of difficult, because what they need is rest. But what is rest and why are we also exhausted?"

He didn't have an answer. I don't think he was supposed to. He was naming what the people in front of him are carrying. Twenty-three years of pastoral attention has made him good at that — noticing what the congregation is actually feeling, not just what the program assumes they need.

## ▪ What a Healthy Church Looks Like from the Inside

---

Billy's answer to the health question came down to one word: discipleship. Not programming, not growth metrics, not cultural preservation.

"A healthy church means that not only coming to the church to be a consumer, but also that you can find your gift and your calling." He was careful to add that the calling might not keep you in the same building: "Not necessarily that you need to stay in the same church, but that you understand that God has a calling for your life." What he is describing is a church that forms people well enough to release them — into other congregations, into other cities, into the next-generation international church that Chun Chun now pastors in Helsinki.

The racial and identity pressures that weigh heavily on Chinese heritage churches in North America — the sense of cultural shame, the friction between being Chinese and being fully at home in the host country — are present in the Nordic context but in a different register. Billy is measured about it: "Of course, when you were young teens, maybe you will think, oh, maybe it's better to be a Caucasian." But he says Chinese people in Sweden carry relatively little of that pressure day to day. The community is small, visible as hardworking, and not a focal point for ethnic tension the way larger immigrant communities sometimes are. "Very, very seldom it's about Chinese people. Chinese people only want to work hard and make money — that's all. No problem. This is not our style." He said it with a laugh, and I think he meant it as affection for his people, not as a critique of anyone.

What the community does carry is the work of holding multiple generations, multiple languages, and multiple national identities in one tent — and finding the thread that connects all of it. For

the NCCC, that thread has been relationship: the camps, the shared ministry, the friendships that stretch from Stockholm to Helsinki to Oslo. The next-generation people in the network don't primarily experience the NCCC as an institution. They experience it as the community where they met their friends, where they served their first camp, where they grew up across borders.

Billy grew up in it, too. He is his church's most lasting product. That is the thing that I think the NCCC has done, quietly and well, for forty years: it has formed people who belong to it the way you belong to a family — not perfectly, not without tension, but with a durability that outlasts any single program or pastor. Whether the structure that created that formation is still the right structure for the next forty years is Billy's live question. He is honest that it is. That honesty, after twenty-three years, is its own kind of health.

---

*Pastor Billy Lo serves as senior pastor of the Stockholm congregation of the Nordic Chinese Christian Church (NCCC), a transnational network spanning Sweden, Norway, Finland, and Denmark. He has been in Chinese heritage church ministry in the Nordic countries for 23 years. This snapshot is drawn from an interview conducted by Pastor Enoch Liao on June 20, 2026, in preparation for the CCCOWE 2026 Explore360 breakout session.*